the limited evidence on migration in the Vedic texts and other sources do convey an eastward migratory movement.[21]

One reason, therefore, for Bihar's ascendance around Pataliputra could be the culmination of an eastward drift of settlement. But another interesting explanation has recently been provided in terms of its unique environmental character based on aridity and rainfall.[22] Bihar forms a transitional zone between the humid areas in the east and the dry areas in the west which made it attractive as a site of interaction between two societies with different agrarian practices. In the dry zone, economic activities apart from agriculture included herding and horse-breeding whereas in the humid zones, agriculture, in particular rice cultivation, supported higher densities. If the eastward migration hypothesis is correct, Pataliputra would emerge as a strategic site as it had drier areas in the south and west suitable to the migrant's agrarian practices, access to the mineral resources of the Chhota Nagpur Plateau below and to bountiful agriculture supported by relatively more fertile soil in the north and east in the humid zones. Further, the southern banks of the Ganga around Patna formed a ridge that was amenable for the growth of urban markets, towns and kingdoms.

The earliest kingdoms of Bihar were the Magadha kingdoms, and it is there in the middle of the first millennium BCE that we encounter two of the most famous migrants of Bihar of all time—Buddha and Mahavira—who would forever be associated with the religions of Buddhism and Jainism.[23] Their life stories of the royal-turned-ascetic-turned-preacher were similar but the subsequent trajectories of their faiths were not. For many centuries in the first millennium CE, the Buddhist monastery in Nalanda was patronized by the Gupta Empire and later by Harsha, the Emperor of Kannauj, and attracted students and monks from as far as China. Buddhism travelled to some extent within India for a few centuries, but made more headway outside the subcontinent, travelling through merchants and monks along the Silk Road via the northern passes such as Karakoram and others, to places in East Asia. Jainism would make some headway down south but over time drifted westwards towards Gujarat. Today, these two faiths